AXEL: Tilt — Master Build Prompt (Narrative Alternative)

For: Use INSTEAD of AXEL: Resonance if the narrative/anti-casino angle tests stronger than cosmic. **Goal:** Steam-shippable cascading-cluster slot roguelite framed as a heist against rigged casinos. **Philosophy:** Win on narrative, not aesthetic, while same mechanics carry the loop.

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1. Project Overview

AXEL: Tilt — same cascading-cluster mechanic as Resonance, framed as a heist crew rigging the slots that rig players. Each biome is a casino tier (Strip Mall → Backroom → Penthouse → Sky Vault). The "heat" mechanic adds bust risk: every cascade adds heat, max heat = bust.

Why this wins:

- Strongest distinct narrative angle in the sub-genre
- Anti-casino framing = TikTok-policy-safe + discourse magnet (rides the Atlantic gambling-app article wave)
- Doesn't compete on aesthetic with CloverPit/Slots & Daggers — competes on story

Legal: Same as Resonance. Mechanics safe. Theme original.

2. Context Window Management

- **Session 1:** Cascade engine + heat mechanic (Phase 1)
- **Session 2:** Heist framing + biomes (Phase 2)
- **Session 3:** Items + narrative beats (Phase 3)
- **Session 4:** Steam + polish (Phase 4)

3. Tech Stack

Same as AXEL: Resonance — Godot 4, GodotSteam, etc.

4. Reusable Code Reference

- AXEL: ZERO cascade engine
- Re-skin Resonance scaffolding if it exists

5. Segmented TODO List

PHASE 1 — CASCADE + HEAT (Session 1, ~5 days)

- ☐ Cascade engine port from ZERO
- ☐ **Pressure Gauge ("heat"):** +1 per cascade step, bust at 20. Items reduce heat or convert it to multiplier.
- ☐ Vector + photo-collage art style (noir palette)

PHASE 2 — HEIST BIOMES (Session 2, ~6 days)

- ☐ 4 biomes: Strip Mall Casino, Backroom, Penthouse, Sky Vault
- ☐ Narrative beats between biomes (1–2 lines of text + still frame)
- ☐ Boss ante = casino owner / pit boss with mechanic modifier
- ☐ Crew member meta-progression (unlock new starting items)

PHASE 3 — ITEMS + WRITING (Session 3, ~5 days)

- ☐ ~40 items themed as heist tools (lockpicks, signal jammers, marked dice)
- ☐ Short narrative arc across run (~10 text beats)
- ☐ Multiple endings based on heat-management style

PHASE 4 — STEAM + POLISH (Session 4, ~5 days)

- ☐ Steam integration
- ☐ Trailer leads with the moral hook
- ☐ PR angle: pitch op-eds + gambling-harm-reduction press

6. Game-Specific Details

Pressure Gauge: 0 → 20. Items: "Cooling Coil" (-2 heat after cascade), "Signal Jammer" (next cascade adds 0 heat), "Heat Sink" (convert 10 heat → +5× multiplier). **Pricing:** $12.99 launch, $14.99 regular (slight premium for narrative depth)

7. Critical Reminders

- ❌ Don't preach. The narrative is implicit through items + framing, not lectures
- ❌ Don't romanticize gambling — the player IS the one beating the rigged system
- ✅ Lean on **discourse cycles**: pitch coverage to outlets covering gambling-app harm
- ✅ Make the heat mechanic visible at all times — it's the tension driver

8. Launch Checklist

- [ ] Pre-launch op-ed pitch to RPS, Polygon, Kotaku ("the game that lets you beat the slots")
- [ ] Stream outreach: Northernlion, Olexa, narrative-friendly creators
- [ ] Reddit: r/Games, r/IndieGaming with narrative angle
- [ ] Post-launch: narrative DLC ("The Online Casino" — heist against gambling apps)